

What you talked through

Sunday, August 23, 2026 · 7:40 PM

TRIED IN CLASS

HOW IT STARTED

So my fourth period seventh graders — I've got about five kids who just call out constantly, even when someone else is answering. I remind them, it works for two minutes, and honestly the quiet kids have just stopped trying.

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Your Takeaway

The three things this conversation ended with.

WHAT WE EXPLORED

The teacher described five students who call out constantly in fourth period, causing quieter students to disengage, and we discussed replacing verbal reminders with a structured approach: written think time or a neighbor-check before cold-calling.

WHAT I'LL TRY

Start fourth period with the written-answer-then-cold-call structure (including the ten-second neighbor check), and open class with the planned framing about wanting to hear from more voices.

WHAT I'LL NOTICE

Watch how the quiet students respond once they have something written down before being called on — whether that dry run actually lowers the pressure you were worried about.

The Conversation

Everything that was said, in order.

YOU

So my fourth period seventh graders — I've got about five kids who just call out constantly, even when someone else is answering. I remind them, it works for two minutes, and honestly the quiet kids have just stopped trying.

COACH

Yeah, that's the real cost — the quiet kids checking out is worse than the calling out itself. What have you tried besides the verbal reminders — anything structural, like cold-calling or requiring hands for a stretch?

YOU

I did try a points chart for hand-raising last year and honestly it felt babyish for seventh graders, so I dropped it. Cold-calling I've done a little, but I worry it'll put the quiet kids on the spot in a bad way if I just start picking on them randomly.

COACH

Fair worry, but there's a version that softens that — pair cold-calling with think time. Give a question, say "thirty seconds, everyone jots something down," then call on someone by name, calling on a quiet kid to read their own written answer feels a lot less exposed than being cold-called with nothing prepped. Want to try that as your structural fix for the callers, alongside naming the pattern to the class directly?

YOU

That could actually work — giving them something written down first takes the pressure off. I could even do it like "turn and check with your neighbor" for ten seconds before I call on anyone, so nobody's totally blank when I pick them.

COACH

That neighbor-check is a nice extra layer, gives quiet kids a dry run before it's ever public. One thing to nail down before Monday, though — what are you actually going to say to the five callers about why this new structure exists, so it doesn't feel like it came out of nowhere?

YOU

I think I'll just be straight with them, something like "I love that you all know this stuff, but I want to hear from more voices, so we're doing written answer first, then I call on people" — probably say that Monday at the start of class, not spring it on them mid-lesson. Okay, I'll try that with 4th period tomorrow.

COACH

That's a good frame — puts it on getting more voices in, not on calling them out for calling out. Let me know how it lands.

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What Happened Next

The part that turns a conversation into a change.

Tried in class on 8/27/2026

MY NOTE

The written-answer-then-cold-call opener is a keeper — call-outs dropped and three quiet kids raised their hands, which made my day. Open discussion is still loose though, so that's the piece to solve next.